



Data Protection

It is crucial to protect all the financial data and any other sensitive information stored on your business computers from cyber attack. Taking a few basic measures can make the difference between safety and disaster.

Staying secure

Small businesses are more likely to suffer a cyber attack than large ones, since they have less to spend on security and rarely have in-house IT teams. However, effective precautions can be cheap, or even free.

Many cyber attacks target technical weaknesses in computer systems. Make sure your computer hardware includes antivirus software and fire walls (programs that block unauthorized access), and keep them turned on. This will place barriers between your computer

Information security

Protecting your business from online criminals is essential, as successful attacks can be financially damaging and undermine customer and investor confidence. You also have a legal obligation to protect customer data (see pp.212-215). You must take protective measures before any computer systems go live.

Budget for your cybersecurity needs

To safeguard your data, purchase appropriate equipment and software and seek expert advice.

- › **Back up** all business-related data daily and store it securely—and separate from any computer
- › **Store data** on a hard drive and a cloud storage service. A cloud software subscription buys cybersecurity software for all your computers
- › **Pay for risk analysis** and have the software installed by a certified technician

Introduce essential cybersecurity

Around 80 percent of security breaches can be prevented by installing software to protect systems and control device usage.

- › **Install and switch on** fire wall programs
- › **Install and activate** antivirus software
- › **Update software and firmware** (software fixed into hardware)
- › **Control the use** of USB drives and memory cards
- › **Protect passwords** and make sure they are as strong as possible

